

BODY RECODE · FIELD GUIDE

The Fat Map

v2 · 2026-08-06

Body Recode · Performance Coaching

The Fat Map

Where you store it narrows the field. What comes with it decides.

Almost everything you have read about this is half right. “Belly fat means cortisol” gets repeated with total confidence, and it is wrong often enough to send people down the wrong correction for a year.

Here is why. **Three of the four hormonal drivers push fat toward the middle.** Cortisol does. Insulin does. Falling oestrogen does. Low testosterone does. Only one pattern stores somewhere genuinely separate. So the middle is the most crowded answer on the map, and location on its own cannot tell you who is responsible.

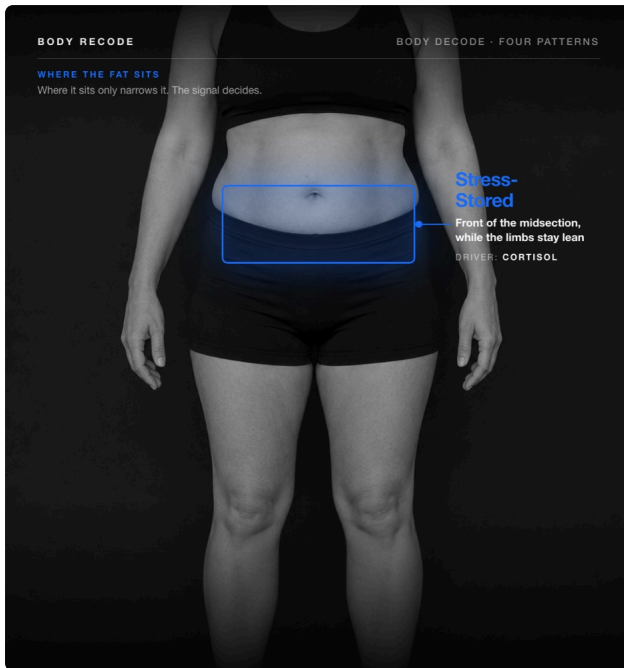
Location narrows it. The signal that comes with it decides it.

That is what this page is. Four pairs, each one a place *plus* the tell that confirms it, drawn on a body so you can see what is actually being described.

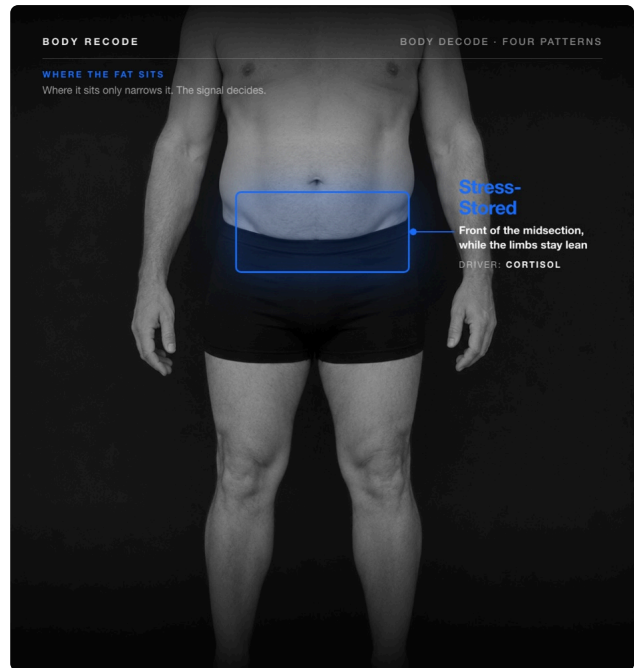
A note on the plates. Two of the four are anatomical locations and are drawn as such. One is drawn on the back, because that is where it sits. The fourth has no marker at all, because it is a change in composition rather than a place. Each pattern is shown on the figure it can actually apply to.

1. Stress-Stored · cortisol

Where: central and toward the front. The belly and waist.



Front of the midsection, limbs staying lean



The same pattern, same place, on a male figure

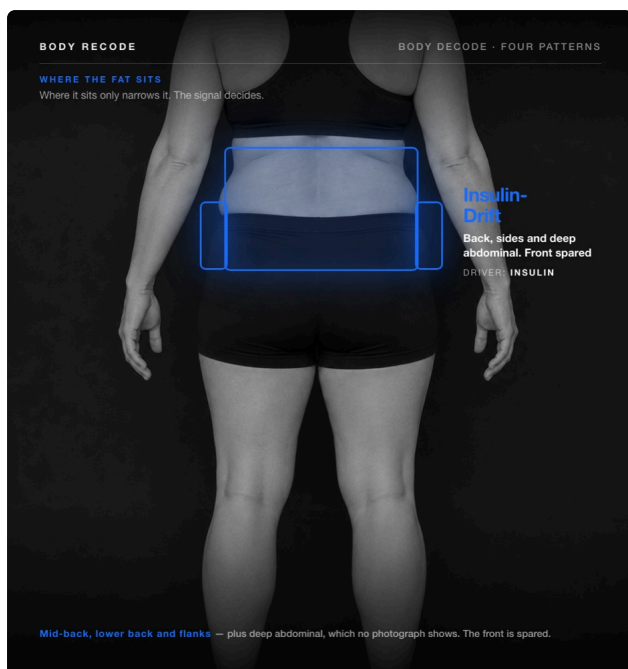
The tell that confirms it: *the middle fills while your arms and legs get thinner.*

That combination is the whole read, and it is the part a photograph cannot show you on its own. Fat arriving centrally at the same time as the limbs lose size is the signature, and it is the one thing insulin does not do. Visceral fat carries about four times the density of the receptors cortisol acts on, plus more of the enzyme that reactivates cortisol inside the fat cell itself, which is why the effect concentrates there rather than spreading.

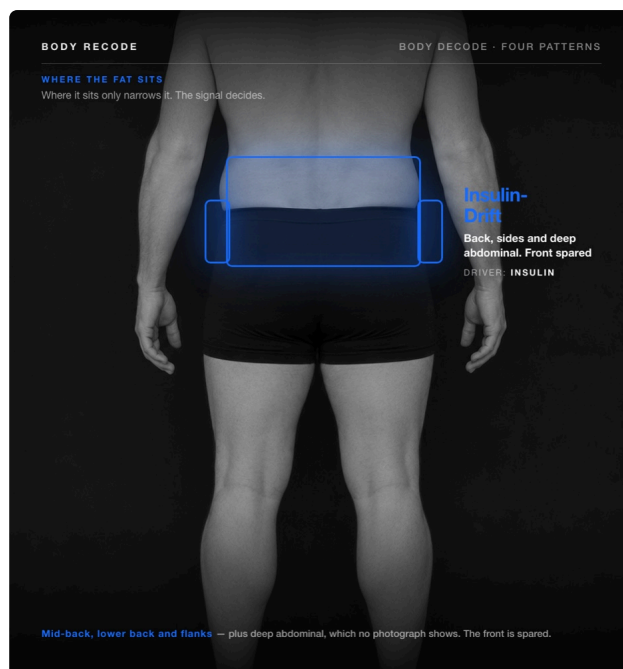
What it answers to: conditions, not effort. Cutting food harder on this pattern adds another stressor to a body already defending itself, and it holds tighter.

2. Insulin-Drift · insulin

Where: the back and the sides. Mid-back, lower back, the flanks and love handles, with a firm full waist. The front is often relatively spared.



Mid-back, lower back and flanks. The front is spared



The same pattern on a male figure

These two are the only plates here shot from behind, and that is the point. Everyone checks the front. This pattern shows itself at the back, which is why it gets missed.

The tell that confirms it: *timing*. An afternoon crash and cravings in the evening.

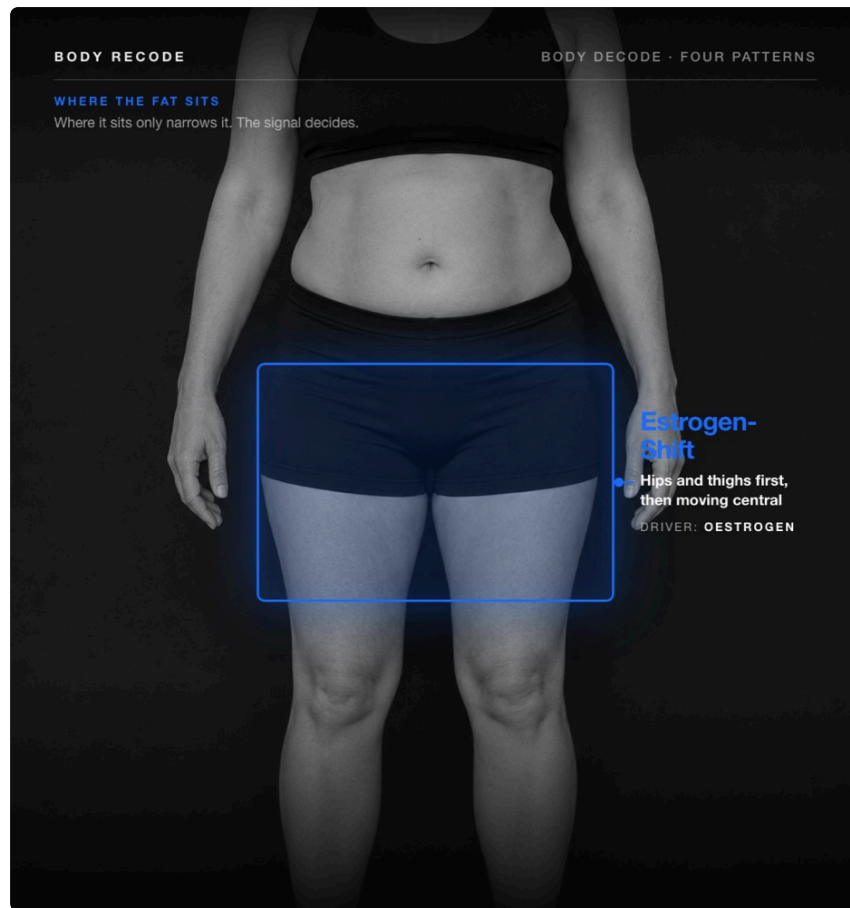
Front versus back is what cleanly separates this from cortisol. The mid-back skinfold is one of the strongest single predictors of insulin resistance there is, in some studies outperforming a scan for visceral fat.

One correction worth making: softening evenly all over is **not** an insulin sign. The superficial layer of fat, the one that reads as general softness, has no insulin association at all. It is the deep layer that tracks with it, and no photograph shows you the deep layer.

What it answers to: this is the one pattern where eating less and moving more is genuinely fair. Reduce the load and it responds.

3. Estrogen-Shift · oestrogen · women only

This one has **two phases that look different and take opposite corrections**, which is why it gets misread more than any other.



Estrogen-Shift, phase one, on the female figure

Phase one, oestrogen present. Storage sits on the hips, glutes and outer thighs, as drawn above. Cycles still regular.

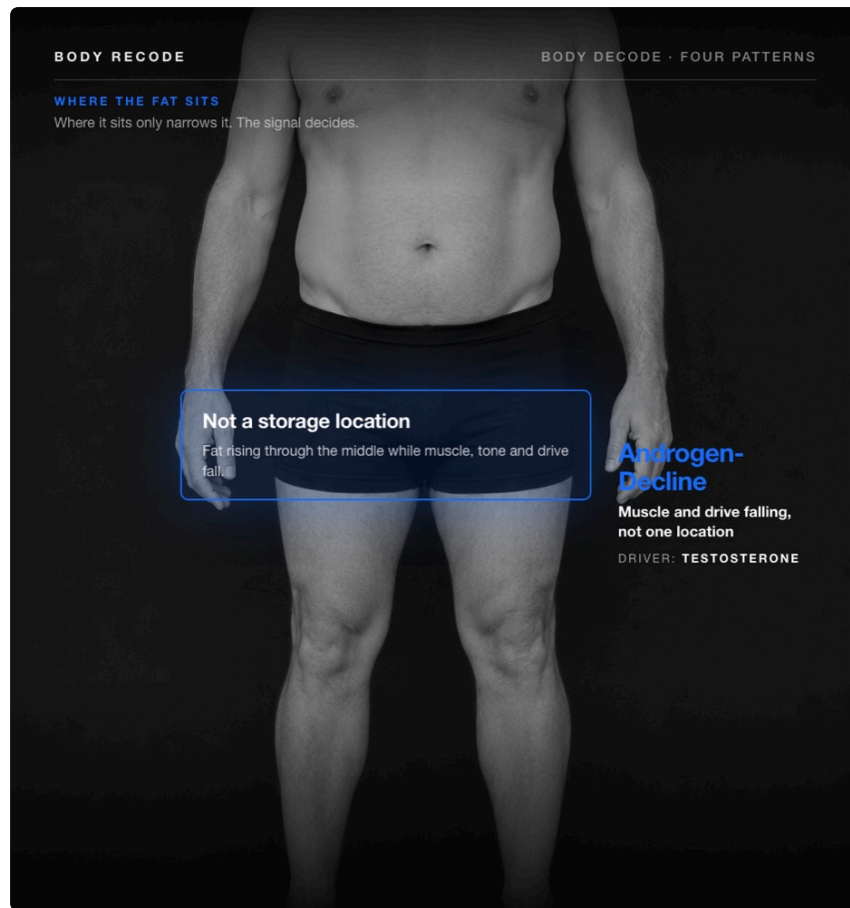
Phase two, oestrogen declining. That same fat starts redistributing to the abdomen while lean mass falls. Perimenopause and after. **There is no plate for phase two, and that is deliberate:** on the body it looks like the cortisol plate at the top of this page. Location cannot separate them.

The tell that confirms it: *cycle status, and the direction of travel.* Not the location by itself. A woman in phase two stores centrally and looks, on location alone, exactly like cortisol.

What it answers to: restriction reads as scarcity here. The body conserves harder, and the harder you push the tighter the hold.

4. Androgen-Divide · testosterone · men only

Where: this one is not a location at all. It is a change in composition.



Androgen-Dcline on the male figure, with no zone marked

Central fat rises, lean mass falls, the chest fills out, drive and recovery both slip. Notice that the plate marks no zone. There is nothing to draw, and that absence is the read.

The tell that confirms it: *the muscle going, not the fat arriving.* Fat gain alone does not type it. Muscle and drive falling together does.

The chest change is real but it is oestrogen-mediated rather than a fat-distribution quirk: the enzyme in fat tissue converts testosterone to estradiol, so more fat means more conversion, which means less testosterone, which means more fat. Arms look soft from losing muscle, not from gaining fat.

What it answers to: aggressive dieting costs you the muscle you were trying to protect, so it makes this one worse.

The two-minute version

PATTERN	WHERE	THE SIGNAL THAT DECIDES IT
Stress-Stored	Front belly, waist	Middle fills while limbs thin
Insulin-Drift	Mid-back, lower back, flanks	Afternoon crash, evening cravings
Estrogen-Shift (F)	Hips/glutes/thighs, later the middle	Cycle status + direction of travel
Androgen-Divide (M)	Not a place. Composition	Muscle and drive falling

Read the middle column on its own and three of the four rows point at roughly the same place. Read the right-hand column and they separate cleanly. That is the entire argument of this page.

Two honest warnings

If nothing here fits cleanly, that is a real answer, not a failure. Plenty of bodies do not type on storage alone, and a body that is genuinely responding well will not type at all. Forcing yourself into the closest-looking box is how people end up running a correction aimed at a driver they do not have.

This page narrows the field. It does not give you a verdict. A pattern is a read, and a read can change as the body changes. Anyone offering you a permanent label from a photograph is selling something.

Want the actual read rather than a best guess?

The free 14-day Body Decode Challenge takes an intake on day zero, scores eight markers against your own baseline on day seven, and gives you the full pattern read on day fourteen. Which of the four is running yours, and what that specific one answers to.

Free. Nothing to pay to get the read.

bodyrecode.au/challenge